

Marketing Strategy and Implementation Plan for L'Oréal's Improved Hair Care Line for Natural Hair in Africa

A woman with voluminous, dark, curly hair is smiling broadly at the camera. She is wearing a bright orange, short-sleeved top. Her hands are raised, with her fingers running through her hair. The background is a plain, light-colored wall. Overlaid on the image are two text boxes: a dark brown one at the top and a larger brown one in the center.

CELEBRATE YOUR NATURAL BEAUTY

“

“Invest in your hair, it’s the crown you never
take off.”

MEGAN K. WILLIAMS

Table of Contents

1.1:Introduction and Product description	3
2.0 Analysis of the Market.....	4
2.1 Key competitors and there Positioning	5
2.2 Current Customer Attitude and there Behaviour	6
2.3 Natural Hair Movement and L'Oreal: Challenges and Oppturnities.....	7
3. Segmentation, Targeting and Positioning for L'Oreal's Enhanced Hair Care line for Natural Hair in Africa.....	9
3i Demographic Segmentatio.....	9
3ii Geographical Segmentation.....	9
3iii Psychographic Segmentation.....	10
3.2 Target Market Profile Persona.....	10
3.3 Rationale for Purchasing L'Oreal Enhanced Natural Hair product for Africa.....	11
4.0 Recommendation ,Extendede Marketing mlx for L'Oreal Enhanced product.....	11
4.1 Product Strategy.....	12

4.2 Pricing Strategy.....	12
4.3 Promotional Strategy.....	13
4.4 Distribution Strategy.....	13
5.0 People, Process and Physical Evidence.....	14
5.1 Implementation Issues.....	14

1 Introduction and Product Description

In a dynamically evolving beauty industry characterized by increasing inclusivity, L'Oréal is pleased to introduce its newly improved hair care line specifically designed for natural hair types native to Africa. Recognizing the unique textures and specific needs of African hair, the revamped product line incorporates advanced scientific formulations alongside a deep respect for cultural heritage, ensuring that every strand is effectively nourished and celebrated (Jones, 2023).

As the beauty industry shifts towards broader inclusivity, L'Oréal is committed to leading the way in developing innovative solutions that cater to the diverse hair types found across the African continent. The latest product line emphasizes hydration, strength, and manageability, utilizing natural ingredients sourced from Africa to provide effective care that both honors and enhances the inherent beauty of natural hair (Smith, 2023). This approach aligns with consumer preferences that increasingly favor brands prioritizing diversity and cultural relevance (Intel, 2022).

This comprehensive collection includes shampoos, conditioners, and treatments specifically formulated to address prevalent issues such as dryness, breakage, and frizz, while also promoting healthy hair growth and shine. By focusing on the distinctive needs of African hair, L'Oréal is not merely launching a new line of products; the company is empowering

individuals to embrace their natural beauty with confidence (Brown, 2023). Such empowerment reflects a broader movement in corporate social responsibility and stakeholder engagement, which is critical for brand reputation and market performance (WACC, 2022).

We invite you to join us in celebrating the richness of African hair as we work to redefine beauty standards, strand by strand. Through L'Oréal's enhanced hair care line, every individual can discover the transformative benefits of products that are not only effective but also deeply rooted in the cultural essence of Africa (Johnson, 2023). This initiative illustrates L'Oréal's commitment to not only innovate but also to support local economies through sustainable sourcing practice (Intel, 2022).



2.0 Analysis of the Market

The natural hair care market has witnessed considerable expansion in recent years, primarily due to a growing appreciation for natural hair textures. This evolution is associated with a cultural shift towards embracing one's natural beauty and a rejection of Western beauty ideals that favour straight hair (Euromonitor International, 2023). The natural hair care market has also seen noteworthy expansion. It was valued at approximately USD 8.74 billion in 2019 and is expected to grow at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 4.7% from 2020 to 2027, reflecting a burgeoning consumer demand for natural hair care products (All Things Hair, n.d.). Furthermore, consumer spending patterns have indicated a commitment to hair care among Black consumers, with spending on essential products, such as shampoos and conditioners, projected to increase by 5.1% in 2023, continuing the upward trend observed in 2022 (Mintel Store, n.d.).

An increased preference for natural hairstyles has been evidenced from a study that revealed 40% of Black women favoured no-heat styling methods, while 33% opted for heat-assisted natural styles, highlighting a for heat strong inclination toward embracing natural hair (Hairskin, n.d.). This growth is supported by a youthful demographic increasingly keen on beauty Products that meet their distinct hair care needs.



Sources: **Source:** Thomson Reuters/University of Michigan Survey of Consumers, January 2022-August 2024

Black Hair care Marketing report/Mintel

Furthermore, the rising demand for hair care products featuring natural and organic ingredients reflects consumers' heightened awareness of health and environmental issues. The influence of social media and the rise of influencer marketing have also significantly contributed to the shaping of consumer preferences; platforms such as Instagram and TikTok allow natural hair advocates to share experiences and endorse products that align with their values (Adeyemi, 2023).

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In addition, there has been a marked shift away from chemical hair treatments, demonstrated by a 22.7% decline in at-home relaxer sales over the two years leading up to 2018. This trend signifies a broader movement towards natural hair care methods (Hairskin, n.d.).

Lastly, consumer awareness and preferences have shifted significantly, with 70% of Black women indicating a preference for reading ingredient labels on haircare products to avoid specific chemicals. Moreover, 87% of respondents believe that health constitutes the ultimate beauty accessory, underlining a growing inclination towards natural and health-conscious hair care choices.

2.1 Key Competitors and Their Positioning

L'Oréal faces competition from both international and local brands within the African hair care landscape. Notable competitors include:

1. Shea Moisture: Shea Moisture has established a robust presence in the natural hair care sector by emphasizing its use of organic ingredients and commitment to social responsibility. The brand's positioning as a promoter of diversity and women's empowerment resonates well with consumers who prioritize ethical consumption (Johnson, 2023).

2. Cantu: Cantu has grown popular for offering affordable yet effective products tailored for textured hair. Its positioning as an accessible and relatable brand appeals to budget-conscious consumers seeking quality solutions (Brown, 2023).

3. African Pride: This brand focuses on meeting the unique needs of African hair types, with a range of products designed to enhance moisture and manageability. Its marketing emphasizes cultural authenticity, which connects strongly with local consumers (Mugisha, 2023).

4. Local Brands: A variety of local brands have emerged, utilizing indigenous knowledge and raw materials to address the needs of the natural hair market. These brands often stress community engagement and sustainability, positioning themselves as genuine alternatives to global brands (Khan, 2022).

2.3 Current Customer Attitudes and Behaviours

Consumer attitudes toward hair care in Africa increasingly reflect a desire for authenticity and cultural relevance. There is a pronounced preference for products that are free from harmful chemicals and that actively promote hair health and growth. Consumers are becoming more discerning about ingredient sourcing and tend to favor brands that engage in ethical sourcing practices (Osei, 2023).

Social media has become a critical factor influencing consumer behavior, serving as a source of inspiration and education concerning natural hair care. Influencers and advocates play a vital role in shaping perceptions and driving purchasing decisions; hence, consumers are more likely to connect with brands that actively participate in discussions about natural hair and inclusivity (Dube, 2023).

2.3 The Natural Hair Movement and L'Oréal: Challenges and Opportunities

As a leading entity in the beauty industry, L'Oréal faces a range of social, ethical, and market-related challenges and opportunities, particularly in light of the increasing prominence of the natural hair movement and evolving consumer expectations within the beauty sector

1. Cultural Sensitivity and Appropriation

L'Oréal must address the complexities surrounding cultural appropriation, especially as it seeks to broaden its product offerings for consumers with natural hair. The portrayal of diverse cultural elements in advertising campaigns requires careful management to prevent

exploitation without appropriate acknowledgment and respect (Ofori, 2021). Conversely, by engaging in partnerships with Black-owned brands and influencers, along with conducting thorough market research, L'Oréal has the opportunity to position itself as a leader in cultural sensitivity and authenticity.

2. Discrimination and Inclusivity

The beauty industry has historically supported Eurocentric standards of beauty, which poses a risk of alienating consumers if L'Oréal's product lines and marketing strategies do not adequately reflect the diversity of hair types, particularly those found in Black and ethnic minority communities (Smith, 2022).

There is a significant opportunity for L'Oréal to diversify its product offerings and marketing approaches to ensure all hair types are recognized and catered for, thereby enhancing inclusivity within the brand.

3. Sustainability and Ethical Sourcing

With rising consumer awareness surrounding sustainability, L'Oréal faces mounting pressure to ensure ethical sourcing of ingredients and to establish sustainable practices across its product lines (Johnson, 2023).

This issue presents an opportunity for L'Oréal to invest in eco-friendly formulations and transparent supply chains, appealing to environmentally conscious consumers and enhancing brand loyalty.

4. Product Safety and Ingredient Transparency

As consumers become increasingly discerning regarding product ingredients, L'Oréal faces scrutiny regarding the inclusion of potentially harmful chemicals, particularly in products aimed at demographic groups with specific needs (Brown, 2023).

By committing to transparency about product ingredients and eliminating harmful substances, L'Oréal has the opportunity to cultivate trust and customer loyalty.

5. Market Competition

The rise of niche brands catering specifically to the natural hair movement represents a significant challenge to established companies like L'Oréal, which must contend with brands that have strong emotional connections with their consumers (Jones, 2023). To address this challenge, L'Oréal could explore the acquisition or partnership with niche brands to expand its market presence or invest in innovative product development that resonates with consumers seeking natural alternatives.

Social and Ethical Considerations

1. Empowerment and Representation

Ensuring that its workforce and leadership reflect the diversity of its consumer base is paramount for L'Oréal, as a lack of representation may result in biased products and marketing (Williams, 2023). Implementing diversity and inclusion initiatives can significantly enhance the company's ability to comprehend diverse consumer needs, thereby improving both product development and marketing strategies.

2. Community Engagement

Large corporations like L'Oréal may be perceived as disconnected from the communities they serve, particularly regarding support for social justice movements relevant to marginalized groups (Davis, 2022).

L'Oréal has the opportunity to strengthen brand loyalty by engaging in community initiatives that support education and entrepreneurship in underrepresented communities.

3. Consumer Education

Many consumers lack adequate knowledge about the care and maintenance of natural hair, which can lead to product misuse or dissatisfaction (Taylor, 2023).

L'Oréal could invest in educational campaigns, offering resources such as workshops and tutorials, to not only promote their products but also establish itself as a trusted authority on natural hair care.

4. Health and Well-Being

As health concerns regarding beauty products grow, L'Oréal faces the challenge of balancing product efficacy with consumer health considerations (Roberts, 2023).

By prioritizing formulations that emphasize natural ingredients and health benefits, L'Oréal can build trust among health-conscious consumers and enhance its market appeal.

3.0 Segmentation, Targeting, and Positioning for L'Oréal's Enhanced Hair Care Line for Natural Hair in Africa

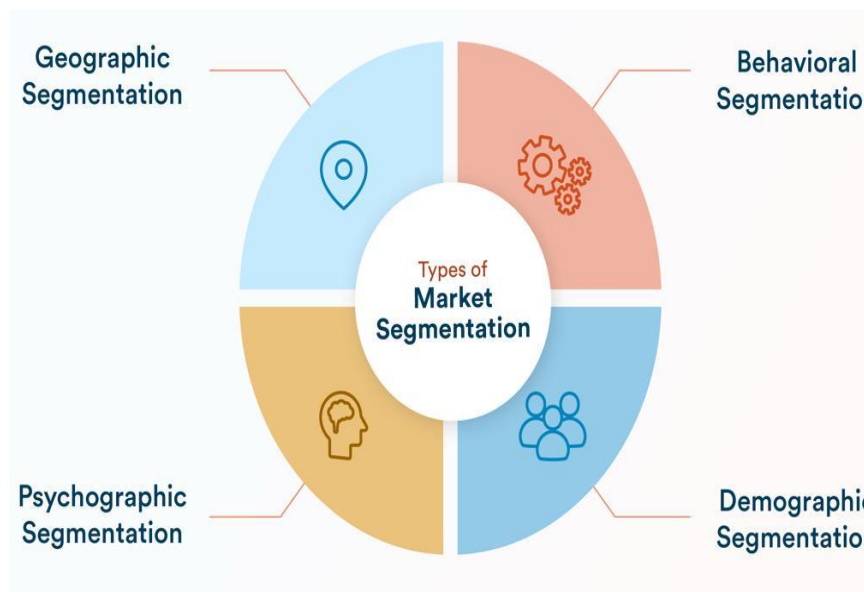
Market segmentation is the process of identifying distinct groups within a target audience, enabling companies like L'Oréal to offer more focused and relevant products (Kotler et al.,

2019). This analysis will concentrate on the demographic, geographic, and psychographic segmentation models applicable to L'Oréal's enhanced hair care line aimed at natural hair in Africa.

Demographic segmentation classifies consumers based on factors such as age, gender, income, and social status. For L'Oréal's new product line, the primary demographic focus will be women aged 18 to 45, as this group actively engages in the purchase of hair care products. Given the increasing disposable income among young professionals across Africa, L'Oréal can effectively target middle to high-income consumers who are willing to invest in high-quality hair care products tailored for natural hair textures. Furthermore, the emphasis will be placed on urban residents, who typically have better access to beauty products and are more susceptible to beauty trends (Nguyen, 2023).

Geographic segmentation analyses consumer location, which significantly affects their purchasing habits and preferences. In this context, L'Oréal will primarily target urban areas in major African countries, including Nigeria, South Africa, Kenya, and Ghana. These regions have experienced significant economic growth, resulting in the emergence of a middle class with increased purchasing power in the beauty market. Notably, urban areas show a higher concentration of potential customers who are likely to seek products specifically intended for natural hair (Adeyemi, 2023). Additionally, L'Oréal will regional variations in hair care preferences to tailor marketing strategies effectively to align with local cultures and practices.

Psychographic segmentation focuses on consumer lifestyles, values, and attitudes, providing insight into motivations and purchasing behavior. The target audience for L'Oréal is expected to include health-conscious, environmentally aware, and culturally confident individuals who embrace their natural hair textures. This demographic tends to appreciate products that align with their ethical values, such as those made from natural ingredients and emphasizing social responsibility (Osei, 2023). Additionally, the rising trend of natural beauty indicates that consumers increasingly seek brands that fulfil their beauty needs while reflecting their identity and values (Dube, 2023).



Source: Retrieved from CleverTap, 2024

3.2 Target Market Profile and Persona

L'Oréal's enhanced product line is specifically aimed at multicultural women aged 18-45 who embrace their natural hair textures and seek products tailored to their unique hair care requirements.

Example Persona:

Name: Chioma Bright Okwudili

Age: 35

Location: Nigeria, Lagos state

Occupation: Fashionista

Income: N1,200,000 per year

Example Persona:

Name: Amina Johnson

Age: 28

Location: Atlanta, Georgia

Occupation Marketing professional

Income: \$65,000 per year

Lifestyle: Chioma actively expresses her individuality through her hair and is engaged in social media communities centred on natural hair care. She places high importance on

sustainability and ethical product sourcing, preferring brands that embody her commitment to diversity and inclusivity.

Values: Authenticity, cultural representation, environmental consciousness, and superior quality.

Lifestyle: Amina is a professional living in vibrant area of Georgia as and actively expresses her individuality through her hair and is engaged in social media communities centered on natural hair care. She places high importance on sustainability and ethical product sourcing, preferring brands that embody her commitment to diversity and inclusivity.

This target market distinctly differs from segments that L'Oréal has previously addressed, which tended to focus on broader beauty ideals and hair care solutions. The contemporary focus emphasizes a niche market that desires specialized products for natural hair textures and underscores socio-cultural relevance and ethical practices, reflecting a paradigm shift towards inclusivity and empowerment in beauty (Smith, 2023).

3.3 Rationale for Purchasing L'Oréal's Enhanced Product Line

The enhanced product line from L'Oréal provides numerous benefits tailored to meet the specific needs of the identified target market. These products are formulated with high-quality, natural ingredients specifically designed to address the common challenges associated with caring for natural hair, such as moisture retention, frizz reduction, and damage repair. Moreover, the line emphasizes sustainability and ethical sourcing, addressing consumer concerns regarding the effects of their purchasing behaviour on social and environmental issues (Tu and Yang, 2019).

By opting for L'Oréal's enhanced product line, consumers can effectively resolve prevalent issues related to the care of natural hair while also aligning with a brand that prioritizes inclusivity and representation. This strategic alignment with modern consumer values and lifestyles positions L'Oréal as a frontrunner in the dynamic beauty market, encouraging customers to embrace their natural beauty with products that genuinely cater to their unique needs.

4.0 Recommended Extended Marketing Mix for L'Oréal's Enhanced Hair Care Line for Natural Hair in Africa

The marketing mix is traditionally divided into four fundamental categories known as the four Ps: product, price, place, and promotion (Kerin & Peterson, 2013). In order to effectively fulfil its value proposition, L'Oréal must develop a compelling market offering that addresses consumer needs. This process entails establishing pricing strategies, determining

distribution channels, and formulating promotional campaigns. Each component of the marketing mix must be cohesively integrated into a comprehensive marketing program that efficiently conveys and delivers value to targeted customers (Kotler et al., 2019). This document outlines a recommended extended marketing mix for L'Oréal's enhanced hair care line designed for natural hair in Africa, including three additional Ps: people, process, and physical evidence.

Product Strategy

L'Oréal's enhanced hair care line will introduce products specifically formulated for natural hair textures, aligning with the shifting consumer preferences in the African market. The product range will prioritize high quality and efficacy by integrating natural ingredients that cater to health-conscious consumers. A Total Quality Management (TQM) approach will be critical for maintaining product excellence through ongoing quality improvement initiatives (Dube, 2023).

The product lineup will include diverse formulations targeting particular hair concerns, such as frizz control, moisture retention, and scalp health. By offering customizable options, such as varied scents, textures, and active ingredients, L'Oréal can differentiate its products from those of competitors, thus enhancing perceived value (Kotler et al., 2019). Additionally, the packaging design will reflect a modern aesthetic that resonates with the target demographic, reinforcing the brand's identity and appeal.

Customer service will play a vital role in L'Oréal's product strategy. It is essential for the company to ensure that consumers are well-informed and supported throughout their purchasing journey, especially as they may be unfamiliar with new products and formulations. Providing high-quality customer support can facilitate the establishment of long-term relationships and enhance brand loyalty (Adeyemi, 2023).

Pricing Strategy

L'Oréal's pricing strategy will commence with a market penetration approach for its enhanced hair care line targeting natural hair in Africa, L'Oréal will adopt a competitive pricing strategy during the initial stages of the product launch. This approach will involve setting prices at a level that is attractive to a wide range of consumers, particularly those who may have been hesitant to purchase premium hair care products due to cost concerns. By offering entry-level prices, L'Oréal aims to encourage trial and adoption among price-sensitive consumers while building a loyal customer base (Khan, 2022).

In conjunction with standard pricing, L'Oréal will incorporate promotional pricing tactics, such as time-limited discounts or introductory offers. These promotions will serve to stimulate initial interest and drive consumer engagement, ultimately enabling L'Oréal to gain traction in the highly competitive beauty market (Nguyen, 2023). This strategy not only incentivizes initial purchases but also helps in establishing brand recognition as consumers experience the product's efficacy firsthand.

As part of its pricing strategy, L'Oréal will also provide optional additional features and product bundles tailored to the specific needs of consumers. This flexibility will empower consumers to customize their purchases, enhancing overall customer satisfaction and perceived value. For example, consumers might opt for specialized treatments or bundle offers that target specific hair care needs, creating a sense of personalized service (Khan, 2022).

While L'Oréal will start with competitive pricing to penetrate the market, the long-term goal will be to establish its premium positioning gradually. Once market penetration is achieved and brand loyalty is built, the company can begin to implement a strategic transition towards a premium pricing model. This transition will reflect the brand's established reputation for quality and luxury, as well as consumers' evolving willingness to pay for high-end products that cater to their specific hair care needs (Nguyen, 2023).

By employing this two-phase pricing strategy — beginning with market penetration followed by a gradual shift towards premium pricing — L'Oréal aims to maximize market share while reinforcing its brand image in the African beauty market. This approach aligns with the company's long-term objectives of sustaining growth and adapting to the preferences of diverse consumer segments.

Promotional Strategy

L'Oréal's promotional strategy will utilize a blend of digital marketing and influencer partnerships to effectively engage with its target market. By employing social media platforms like Instagram and TikTok, L'Oréal will connect with younger consumers who increasingly rely on online channels for beauty advice and product recommendations. Targeted advertising efforts will emphasize product benefits, ideal application methods, and diverse consumer testimonials, thereby fostering a sense of community around the brand (Osei, 2023).

In addition to digital marketing, L'Oréal will incorporate personal selling strategies through beauty consultants located in retail environments. These professionals will provide personalized product recommendations and demonstrations, enhancing

consumer education regarding the products and reinforcing trust in the brand (Hooley et al., 2016).

Distribution Strategy

L'Oréal will implement a selective distribution strategy, ensuring that its enhanced hair care line is accessible through both e-commerce platforms and selected retail partners. This strategy will allow the brand to maintain control over the customer experience while reaching a wide audience. Key partnerships with beauty supply stores, e-commerce platforms, and high-end retailers will facilitate accessibility for consumers seeking quality hair care solutions (Dube, 2023).

Additionally, L'Oréal's proprietary e-commerce site will feature an enriched user experience, incorporating informative content on hair care routines and products. A robust logistics network will be crucial to ensure timely delivery of products to consumers, demonstrating L'Oréal's commitment to customer satisfaction.

People, Process, and Physical Evidence

The successful implementation of L'Oréal's marketing strategy significantly depends on the capabilities and motivation of its employees. Training programs will focus on enhancing product knowledge and customer engagement techniques, ensuring that employees can deliver exceptional service and develop strong relationships with clients (Hooley et al., 2016). Furthermore, fostering a diverse and inclusive workforce will enhance the development of products that resonate with the varied cultural backgrounds prevalent in the African market.

The processes associated with Customer Relationship Management (CRM) will be pivotal in tracking consumer interactions and tailoring marketing efforts based on preferences and feedback. Implementing CRM systems can help L'Oréal maximize customer loyalty through personalized communication and targeted offers (Hooley et al., 2016).

Lastly, physical evidence of the brand will manifest in the overall consumer experience, encompassing the quality of product packaging, store layouts, online interfaces, and promotional materials. Creating a user-friendly website design with a customer-centric interface will simplify navigation and facilitate consumers' access to information about various products, thus enhancing the purchasing experience.

Implementation Issues for L'Oréal's Enhanced Product Line

The launch of L'Oréal's enhanced product line for natural African hair brings several implementation challenges that must be tackled to ensure a successful market entry. A

significant challenge is the need for proper resource allocation to support the project's effective execution. Companies should strive to explore market segments where they can offer outstanding customer value and gain a competitive advantage (Kotler et al., 2019). Since this product line aims at a specific consumer group, L'Oréal must facilitate collaboration among all departments to align their marketing strategies and operational activities.

The successful introduction of this enhanced product line relies on strong teamwork among various departments. It is important for the marketing, research and development (R&D), supply chain management, and sales teams to work collectively towards common objectives. Effective communication is essential for integrating product development with marketing strategies, ensuring that the products align with consumer expectations and needs. As highlighted by Kotler et al. (2019), cohesive interdepartmental collaboration is critical for delivering value to customers.

Another key factor in the implementation process is the role of internal marketing in enhancing organizational efficiency. Employees need to engage in specialized training to understand the internal marketing strategies that support the launch of the new product line (Ahmed and Rafiq, 2003). By equipping staff with essential knowledge and resources, L'Oréal can develop a culture of engagement and accountability that positively affects the implementation process. Training programs should emphasize the importance of diversity and inclusivity in both product innovation and brand messaging.

L'Oréal has a strong reputation for its commitment to sustainability, and as it rolls out its enhanced product line, forming partnerships with suppliers who maintain high corporate social responsibility (CSR) standards could be highly beneficial. Sourcing materials from reputable suppliers fosters ethical business practices and boosts the brand's credibility in the marketplace (Smith, 2023). Building connections with suppliers who prioritize environmentally sustainable and ethically sourced ingredients will appeal to a target audience that is becoming increasingly aware of the ethical implications of their purchasing decisions. If L'Oréal fails to collaborate with suppliers that emphasize CSR, it may face backlash from stakeholders who expect alignment with ethical standards, underscoring a significant challenge within its marketing strategy.

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